

# WHAT'S THE FIRST THING AN ACTOR LEARNS? "THE SHOW MUST GO ON!"

## SINGIN' IN THE RAIN / 1952

### IN CONTEXT

#### GENRE

**Musical, satire**

#### DIRECTORS

**Gene Kelly, Stanley Donen**

#### WRITERS

**Betty Comden,  
Adolph Green**

#### STARS

**Gene Kelly, Donald  
O'Connor, Debbie Reynolds**

#### BEFORE

**1927** *The Jazz Singer* is the world's first feature-length "talkie." It is mentioned in the plot of *Singin' in the Rain*.

**1945** For *Anchors Aweigh*, Kelly was given free rein to create his own dance routines.

#### AFTER

**2011** *The Artist* revisits the end of silent movies and the birth of cinematic sound.

**F**rom *A Star Is Born* in 1937 to *The Artist* in 2011, the movie industry has exhibited a narcissistic obsession with itself. Drawing on its own experiences of studios stifling creativity, the

corrupting influence of fame and money, and the compromises they make for the sake of their careers, many filmmakers have made satires about the movies. *Singin' in the Rain* approaches the movie industry with more affection than others. It sees Hollywood, despite its decadence and eccentricities, as a place where talent can thrive, and it remains one of the finest examples of why that optimism is justified: a movie so brimming with creativity and invention that more than 60 years later, it retains the capacity to inspire and entertain.

### End of an era

*Singin' in the Rain* is set in the late 1920s, toward the end of the silent-movie era, and it deals with the need for a studio and its silent star, Don Lockwood (Gene Kelly), to

*Singin' in the Rain* is considered one of the all-time great musicals for its gentle satirizing of Hollywood mores.

